

Competitive Battlecard: Airbnb Experiences

Target segment under test: friend groups on milestone trips, organised by an existing Roamly user. Roamly has no sales team, so this is a positioning pressure test rather than rep enablement. "Win the deal" means winning the moment an organiser decides where to book.

1 · KNOW THE LANDSCAPE

Competitor overview

Locally hosted activities sold inside Airbnb, surfaced next to an accommodation booking. Serves travellers already in the Airbnb funnel. Positions on authenticity and local hosts, the same axis Roamly built its reputation on. They hold the vocabulary Roamly would otherwise claim.

Key offerings

- Host-led local experiences, browsable by destination
- Discovery inside the stay-booking flow
- Single-payer checkout
- No native group coordination, no split payment

Pricing

- **Experiences:** a separate 20% fee paid by the host, against 15.5% for most stay hosts. *Third-party industry reporting, June 2026. Not verified against Airbnb documentation.*
- **The shift that matters more:** Airbnb consolidated to a flat host-side fee. The guest no longer pays a separate service fee and sees one all-in price, replacing the old split of roughly 3% host plus 14.1% to 16.5% guest.

Implication for Roamly. Airbnb has spent a year training travellers to expect one number at checkout. Any Roamly coordination fee runs against that expectation. Carry this into Module 5.

2 · UNDERSTAND THE BATTLEFIELD

Key strengths

- **Distribution adjacency.** Experiences appear at the moment someone books a stay. Roamly must be sought out.
- **Brand trust** at the scale required to hold other people's money.
- **Identical authenticity positioning**, with far more reach behind it.
- **Engineering resource** to rebuild group payments faster than Roamly could defend the position.
- **A clean single price at checkout**, now an expectation they set market-wide.

Key weaknesses

- **They built this and switched it off.** Split payments launched globally in 2017 and were retired in mid-September 2018 as a failed experiment. No native option since. Groups divide costs manually or with third-party tools.
- **No participant identity in a group booking**, so no acquisition loop. Airbnb itself reported that 30% of group reservations led to new users joining. *2017 company figure, directional.* That is the value they walked away from.
- **A 20% Experiences take rate against 15.5% on stays** pressures experience-host economics. A supply-side opening against Roamly's 12,000 vetted hosts.
- **Discovery is destination-led, not occasion-led.** Nobody opens Airbnb thinking about organising a friend's fortieth. *Inference from product structure.*
- **Possible under-investment relative to stays.** *Weak assumption. Airbnb relaunched Experiences in 2025 as a strategic priority, which cuts against it. Verify before relying on this.*

3 · WIN THE DEAL

Why you win

Occasion-led rather than destination-led discovery, with the coordination layer as the product rather than a checkout option.

Why it is defensible: a marketplace design decision, not a feature. It requires participant identity, a liability model for partial payment, and host capacity for parties. Each is a structural commitment. Airbnb deprioritised all three once already.

Why they win

Distribution. If the organiser is already inside Airbnb booking a stay, Roamly never enters the consideration set. At the discovery stage distribution beats product, and Roamly's Module 1 plan explicitly excluded paid acquisition, so there is currently no answer to this. They also carry more brand permission to hold a stranger's money, and more payments engineering than Roamly will have.

Why you

Against the status quo as much as against Airbnb. The status quo is free, so the reason cannot be price.

The booking, the money and the group live in the same object, so the organiser stops being the bank.

4 · HANDLE THE HARD MOMENTS

Quick dismiss

Airbnb sells an experience to one traveller with a card. Roamly is built for the eight people who have to agree first.

Landmine questions

- When you book that for the group, who fronts the money, and how do you get it back?
- Does the platform know who else is coming, or only who paid?
- What happens if two people drop out a week before?
- Why did they turn split payments off in 2018?

Objection handling

Objection	Response
"We'll just use Airbnb and Splitwise."	The real competitor, and it works until someone does not pay. The friction is not the arithmetic, it is that the booking confirms before the money does. Airbnb's own survey found 38% of group travellers had not received all the money owed, and 43% of those had lost \$1,000 or more. <i>Airbnb-commissioned survey, c. 2017.</i>
"Airbnb has more experiences."	True, and irrelevant at eight people. Breadth serves a solo traveller browsing. Vetting serves someone whose friends will blame them for a bad pick.
"Isn't Airbnb about to build this?"	They built it and switched it off. A real risk, not a dismissible one. The defence is the acquisition loop and host readiness for parties, neither of which ships in a sprint.
"Why pay a coordination fee when Airbnb shows one all-in price?"	No answer yet. Unresolved, and it goes to Module 5.

WHAT THIS CHANGES ABOUT THE MODULE 1 STRATEGY

The uncomfortable section is *why they win*, and the answer is distribution. Module 1 explicitly ruled out paid acquisition on the grounds that demand is already in the funnel and distribution is already earned. The competitive read says distribution, not product, is where this launch is most likely to fail.

I want to revisit the no-paid-acquisition decision, because owning the occasion-led search that Airbnb does not serve may be the only defensible distribution Roamly can build before Airbnb notices.

COMPETITOR TIERING

Tier	Who	Action
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Primary	Airbnb Experiences	This battlecard. Both curated supply and prior experience of the mechanic.
Secondary	Takeoff, AvoSquado, TripProf	All-in-one group coordination with split payments, but no inventory. Takeoff is closest to the wedge. Monitor positioning.
Secondary	GetYourGuide, Viator	Compete on inventory and search, not on this segment. Group is a supply-side pricing construct, not coordination.
Real incumbent	WhatsApp + spreadsheet + Splitwise	Free, installed, socially default. Currently winning, on Roamly's own platform.

Strategic bet to be appended in Exercise 2.